



## UnitedHealthcare® Commercial and Individual Exchange Medical Policy

# Magnetic Resonance Imaging (MRI) and Computed Tomography (CT) Scan – Site of Service

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[Instructions for Use](#)

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### Related Commercial/Individual Exchange Policies

- [Breast Imaging for Screening and Diagnosing Cancer](#)
- [Preventive Care Services](#)

## Application

### UnitedHealthcare Commercial

This Medical Policy applies to UnitedHealthcare Commercial benefit plans, except UnitedHealthcare West benefit plans.

### UnitedHealthcare Individual Exchange

This Medical Policy applies to Individual Exchange benefit plans in all states except for Colorado, Maryland, Texas, and Wisconsin.

## Coverage Rationale

A magnetic resonance imaging (MRI) or computed tomography (CT) imaging procedure in the hospital outpatient department is considered medically necessary for individuals who meet any of the following criteria:

- Under 18 years of age
- Require obstetrical observation
- Require perinatology services
- Have a known allergy to a contrast agent used for the procedure
- Have a known chronic disease undergoing active treatment, when direct comparison to prior studies requires the same imaging protocol or equipment obtained at the same hospital-based facility where the procedure is requested
- Have a systemic cancer on active treatment, when restaging studies require the same imaging protocol or equipment used for prior studies obtained at the same hospital-based facility where the procedure is requested
- Pre-procedure imaging which is done within 24 hours of the interventional or surgical procedure and is an integral part of the planned procedure
- Are scheduled for the MRI/CT imaging procedure within 24 hours of a hospital specialist appointment at the same hospital-based facility where the procedure is requested
- Are participating in a clinical trial that requires a specific imaging protocol or equipment not available in a freestanding facility

An MRI/CT imaging procedure in the hospital outpatient department is also considered medically necessary when there are no geographically accessible appropriate alternative sites for the individual to undergo the procedure, including but not limited to the following:

- Moderate or deep sedation or general anesthesia is required for the procedure and freestanding facility providing such sedation is not available; or

- The equipment for the size of the individual is not available; or
- Open MRI is required because the member has a documented diagnosis of claustrophobia and/or severe anxiety which is not available in a freestanding facility

An MRI/CT imaging procedure in the hospital outpatient department is considered medically necessary when imaging in a physician's office or freestanding imaging center would reasonably be expected to delay care and adversely impact health outcome.

All other MRI/CT imaging procedures at a hospital-based imaging department or facility are considered not medically necessary. This includes but is not limited to imaging for:

- Cancer screening
- Initial diagnosis and/or initial staging for suspected or known cancer
- Surveillance of cancer in remission with no clinical suspicion for change in disease status
- Non-cancerous musculoskeletal conditions

**Note:** Authorization is not required for procedures performed in an emergency room, observation unit, urgent care center, or during an inpatient stay.

## Medical Records Documentation Used for Reviews

Benefit coverage for health services is determined by the member specific benefit plan document and applicable laws that may require coverage for a specific service. Medical records documentation may be required to assess whether the member meets the clinical criteria for coverage but does not guarantee coverage of the service requested; refer to the protocol titled [Medical Records Documentation Used for Reviews](#).

## Applicable Codes

The following list(s) of procedure and/or diagnosis codes is provided for reference purposes only and may not be all inclusive. Listing of a code in this policy does not imply that the service described by the code is a covered or non-covered health service. Benefit coverage for health services is determined by the member specific benefit plan document and applicable laws that may require coverage for a specific service. The inclusion of a code does not imply any right to reimbursement or guarantee claim payment. Other Policies and Guidelines may apply.

| CPT Code                   | Description                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
|----------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Computed Tomography</b> |                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
| 0042T                      | Cerebral perfusion analysis using computed tomography with contrast administration, including post-processing of parametric maps with determination of cerebral blood flow, cerebral blood volume, and mean transit time |
| 70450                      | Computed tomography, head or brain; without contrast material                                                                                                                                                            |
| 70460                      | Computed tomography, head or brain; with contrast material(s)                                                                                                                                                            |
| 70470                      | Computed tomography, head or brain; without contrast material, followed by contrast material(s) and further sections                                                                                                     |
| 70480                      | Computed tomography, orbit, sella, or posterior fossa or outer, middle, or inner ear; without contrast material                                                                                                          |
| 70481                      | Computed tomography, orbit, sella, or posterior fossa or outer, middle, or inner ear; with contrast material(s)                                                                                                          |
| 70482                      | Computed tomography, orbit, sella, or posterior fossa or outer, middle, or inner ear; without contrast material, followed by contrast material(s) and further sections                                                   |
| 70486                      | Computed tomography, maxillofacial area; without contrast material                                                                                                                                                       |
| 70487                      | Computed tomography, maxillofacial area; with contrast material(s)                                                                                                                                                       |
| 70488                      | Computed tomography, maxillofacial area; without contrast material, followed by contrast material(s) and further sections                                                                                                |
| 70490                      | Computed tomography, soft tissue neck; without contrast material                                                                                                                                                         |
| 70491                      | Computed tomography, soft tissue neck; with contrast material(s)                                                                                                                                                         |

| CPT Code                   | Description                                                                                                                                            |
|----------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Computed Tomography</b> |                                                                                                                                                        |
| 70492                      | Computed tomography, soft tissue neck; without contrast material followed by contrast material(s) and further sections                                 |
| 70496                      | Computed tomographic angiography, head, with contrast material(s), including noncontrast images, if performed, and image postprocessing                |
| 70498                      | Computed tomographic angiography, neck, with contrast material(s), including noncontrast images, if performed, and image postprocessing                |
| 71250                      | Computed tomography, thorax, diagnostic; without contrast material                                                                                     |
| 71260                      | Computed tomography, thorax, diagnostic; with contrast material(s)                                                                                     |
| 71270                      | Computed tomography, thorax, diagnostic; without contrast material, followed by contrast material(s) and further sections                              |
| 71271                      | Computed tomography, thorax, low dose for lung cancer screening, without contrast material(s)                                                          |
| 71275                      | Computed tomographic angiography, chest (noncoronary), with contrast material(s), including noncontrast images, if performed, and image postprocessing |
| 72125                      | Computed tomography, cervical spine; without contrast material                                                                                         |
| 72126                      | Computed tomography, cervical spine; with contrast material                                                                                            |
| 72127                      | Computed tomography, cervical spine; without contrast material, followed by contrast material(s) and further sections                                  |
| 72128                      | Computed tomography, thoracic spine; without contrast material                                                                                         |
| 72129                      | Computed tomography, thoracic spine; with contrast material                                                                                            |
| 72130                      | Computed tomography, thoracic spine; without contrast material, followed by contrast material(s) and further sections                                  |
| 72131                      | Computed tomography, lumbar spine; without contrast material                                                                                           |
| 72132                      | Computed tomography, lumbar spine; with contrast material                                                                                              |
| 72133                      | Computed tomography, lumbar spine; without contrast material, followed by contrast material(s) and further sections                                    |
| 72191                      | Computed tomographic angiography, pelvis, with contrast material(s), including noncontrast images, if performed, and image postprocessing              |
| 72192                      | Computed tomography, pelvis; without contrast material                                                                                                 |
| 72193                      | Computed tomography, pelvis; with contrast material(s)                                                                                                 |
| 72194                      | Computed tomography, pelvis; without contrast material, followed by contrast material(s) and further sections                                          |
| 73200                      | Computed tomography, upper extremity; without contrast material                                                                                        |
| 73201                      | Computed tomography, upper extremity; with contrast material(s)                                                                                        |
| 73202                      | Computed tomography, upper extremity; without contrast material, followed by contrast material(s) and further sections                                 |
| 73206                      | Computed tomographic angiography, upper extremity, with contrast material(s), including noncontrast images, if performed, and image postprocessing     |
| 73700                      | Computed tomography, lower extremity; without contrast material                                                                                        |
| 73701                      | Computed tomography, lower extremity; with contrast material(s)                                                                                        |
| 73702                      | Computed tomography, lower extremity; without contrast material, followed by contrast material(s) and further sections                                 |
| 73706                      | Computed tomographic angiography, lower extremity, with contrast material(s), including noncontrast images, if performed, and image postprocessing     |
| 74150                      | Computed tomography, abdomen; without contrast material                                                                                                |
| 74160                      | Computed tomography, abdomen; with contrast material(s)                                                                                                |
| 74170                      | Computed tomography, abdomen; without contrast material, followed by contrast material(s) and further sections                                         |



| CPT Code                          | Description                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
|-----------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Computed Tomography</b>        |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
| 74174                             | Computed tomographic angiography, abdomen and pelvis, with contrast material(s), including noncontrast images, if performed, and image postprocessing                                                                                                                                                                                          |
| 74175                             | Computed tomographic angiography, abdomen, with contrast material(s), including noncontrast images, if performed, and image postprocessing                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
| 74176                             | Computed tomography, abdomen and pelvis; without contrast material                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
| 74177                             | Computed tomography, abdomen and pelvis; with contrast material(s)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
| 74178                             | Computed tomography, abdomen and pelvis; without contrast material in one or both body regions, followed by contrast material(s) and further sections in one or both body regions                                                                                                                                                              |
| 74261                             | Computed tomographic (CT) colonography, diagnostic, including image postprocessing; without contrast material                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
| 74262                             | Computed tomographic (CT) colonography, diagnostic, including image postprocessing; with contrast material(s) including non-contrast images, if performed                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| 74263                             | Computed tomographic (CT) colonography, screening, including image postprocessing                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
| 75571                             | Computed tomography, heart, without contrast material, with quantitative evaluation of coronary calcium                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| 75572                             | Computed tomography, heart, with contrast material, for evaluation of cardiac structure and morphology (including 3D image postprocessing, assessment of cardiac function, and evaluation of venous structures, if performed)                                                                                                                  |
| 75573                             | Computed tomography, heart, with contrast material, for evaluation of cardiac structure and morphology in the setting of congenital heart disease (including 3D image postprocessing, assessment of left ventricular [LV] cardiac function, right ventricular [RV] structure and function and evaluation of vascular structures, if performed) |
| 75574                             | Computed tomographic angiography, heart, coronary arteries and bypass grafts (when present), with contrast material, including 3D image postprocessing (including evaluation of cardiac structure and morphology, assessment of cardiac function, and evaluation of venous structures, if performed)                                           |
| 75635                             | Computed tomographic angiography, abdominal aorta and bilateral iliofemoral lower extremity runoff, with contrast material(s), including noncontrast images, if performed, and image postprocessing                                                                                                                                            |
| 76380                             | Computed tomography, limited or localized follow-up study                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| 76497                             | Unlisted computed tomography procedure (e.g., diagnostic, interventional)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| <b>Magnetic Resonance Imaging</b> |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
| 70336                             | Magnetic resonance (e.g., proton) imaging, temporomandibular joint(s)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
| 70540                             | Magnetic resonance (e.g., proton) imaging, orbit, face, and/or neck; without contrast material(s)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
| 70542                             | Magnetic resonance (e.g., proton) imaging, orbit, face, and/or neck; with contrast material(s)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| 70543                             | Magnetic resonance (e.g., proton) imaging, orbit, face, and/or neck; without contrast material(s), followed by contrast material(s) and further sequences                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| 70544                             | Magnetic resonance angiography, head; without contrast material(s)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
| 70545                             | Magnetic resonance angiography, head; with contrast material(s)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
| 70546                             | Magnetic resonance angiography, head; without contrast material(s), followed by contrast material(s) and further sequences                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
| 70547                             | Magnetic resonance angiography, neck; without contrast material(s)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
| 70548                             | Magnetic resonance angiography, neck; with contrast material(s)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
| 70549                             | Magnetic resonance angiography, neck; without contrast material(s), followed by contrast material(s) and further sequences                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
| 70551                             | Magnetic resonance (e.g., proton) imaging, brain (including brain stem); without contrast material                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
| 70552                             | Magnetic resonance (e.g., proton) imaging, brain (including brain stem); with contrast material(s)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
| 70553                             | Magnetic resonance (e.g., proton) imaging, brain (including brain stem); without contrast material, followed by contrast material(s) and further sequences                                                                                                                                                                                     |

| CPT Code                          | Description                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
|-----------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Magnetic Resonance Imaging</b> |                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| 70554                             | Magnetic resonance imaging, brain, functional MRI; including test selection and administration of repetitive body part movement and/or visual stimulation, not requiring physician or psychologist administration |
| 70555                             | Magnetic resonance imaging, brain, functional MRI; requiring physician or psychologist administration of entire neurofunctional testing                                                                           |
| 71550                             | Magnetic resonance (e.g., proton) imaging, chest (e.g., for evaluation of hilar and mediastinal lymphadenopathy); without contrast material(s)                                                                    |
| 71551                             | Magnetic resonance (e.g., proton) imaging, chest (e.g., for evaluation of hilar and mediastinal lymphadenopathy); with contrast material(s)                                                                       |
| 71552                             | Magnetic resonance (e.g., proton) imaging, chest (e.g., for evaluation of hilar and mediastinal lymphadenopathy); without contrast material(s), followed by contrast material(s) and further sequences            |
| 71555                             | Magnetic resonance angiography, chest (excluding myocardium), with or without contrast material(s)                                                                                                                |
| 72141                             | Magnetic resonance (e.g., proton) imaging, spinal canal and contents, cervical; without contrast material                                                                                                         |
| 72142                             | Magnetic resonance (e.g., proton) imaging, spinal canal and contents, cervical; with contrast material(s)                                                                                                         |
| 72146                             | Magnetic resonance (e.g., proton) imaging, spinal canal and contents, thoracic; without contrast material                                                                                                         |
| 72147                             | Magnetic resonance (e.g., proton) imaging, spinal canal and contents, thoracic; with contrast material(s)                                                                                                         |
| 72148                             | Magnetic resonance (e.g., proton) imaging, spinal canal and contents, lumbar; without contrast material                                                                                                           |
| 72149                             | Magnetic resonance (e.g., proton) imaging, spinal canal and contents, lumbar; with contrast material(s)                                                                                                           |
| 72156                             | Magnetic resonance (e.g., proton) imaging, spinal canal and contents, without contrast material, followed by contrast material(s) and further sequences; cervical                                                 |
| 72157                             | Magnetic resonance (e.g., proton) imaging, spinal canal and contents, without contrast material, followed by contrast material(s) and further sequences; thoracic                                                 |
| 72158                             | Magnetic resonance (e.g., proton) imaging, spinal canal and contents, without contrast material, followed by contrast material(s) and further sequences; lumbar                                                   |
| 72159                             | Magnetic resonance angiography, spinal canal and contents, with or without contrast material(s)                                                                                                                   |
| 72195                             | Magnetic resonance (e.g., proton) imaging, pelvis; without contrast material(s)                                                                                                                                   |
| 72196                             | Magnetic resonance (e.g., proton) imaging, pelvis; with contrast material(s)                                                                                                                                      |
| 72197                             | Magnetic resonance (e.g., proton) imaging, pelvis; without contrast material(s), followed by contrast material(s) and further sequences                                                                           |
| 72198                             | Magnetic resonance angiography, pelvis, with or without contrast material(s)                                                                                                                                      |
| 73218                             | Magnetic resonance (e.g., proton) imaging, upper extremity, other than joint; without contrast material(s)                                                                                                        |
| 73219                             | Magnetic resonance (e.g., proton) imaging, upper extremity, other than joint; with contrast material(s)                                                                                                           |
| 73220                             | Magnetic resonance (e.g., proton) imaging, upper extremity, other than joint; without contrast material(s), followed by contrast material(s) and further sequences                                                |
| 73221                             | Magnetic resonance (e.g., proton) imaging, any joint of upper extremity; without contrast material(s)                                                                                                             |
| 73222                             | Magnetic resonance (e.g., proton) imaging, any joint of upper extremity; with contrast material(s)                                                                                                                |
| 73223                             | Magnetic resonance (e.g., proton) imaging, any joint of upper extremity; without contrast material(s), followed by contrast material(s) and further sequences                                                     |
| 73225                             | Magnetic resonance angiography, upper extremity, with or without contrast material(s)                                                                                                                             |



| CPT Code                          | Description                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
|-----------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Magnetic Resonance Imaging</b> |                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |
| 73718                             | Magnetic resonance (e.g., proton) imaging, lower extremity other than joint; without contrast material(s)                                                                                                                 |
| 73719                             | Magnetic resonance (e.g., proton) imaging, lower extremity other than joint; with contrast material(s)                                                                                                                    |
| 73720                             | Magnetic resonance (e.g., proton) imaging, lower extremity other than joint; without contrast material(s), followed by contrast material(s) and further sequences                                                         |
| 73721                             | Magnetic resonance (e.g., proton) imaging, any joint of lower extremity; without contrast material                                                                                                                        |
| 73722                             | Magnetic resonance (e.g., proton) imaging, any joint of lower extremity; with contrast material(s)                                                                                                                        |
| 73723                             | Magnetic resonance (e.g., proton) imaging, any joint of lower extremity; without contrast material(s), followed by contrast material(s) and further sequences                                                             |
| 73725                             | Magnetic resonance angiography, lower extremity, with or without contrast material(s)                                                                                                                                     |
| 74181                             | Magnetic resonance (e.g., proton) imaging, abdomen; without contrast material(s)                                                                                                                                          |
| 74182                             | Magnetic resonance (e.g., proton) imaging, abdomen; with contrast material(s)                                                                                                                                             |
| 74183                             | Magnetic resonance (e.g., proton) imaging, abdomen; without contrast material(s), followed by with contrast material(s) and further sequences                                                                             |
| 74185                             | Magnetic resonance angiography, abdomen, with or without contrast material(s)                                                                                                                                             |
| 75557                             | Cardiac magnetic resonance imaging for morphology and function without contrast material                                                                                                                                  |
| 75559                             | Cardiac magnetic resonance imaging for morphology and function without contrast material; with stress imaging                                                                                                             |
| 75561                             | Cardiac magnetic resonance imaging for morphology and function without contrast material(s), followed by contrast material(s) and further sequences;                                                                      |
| 75563                             | Cardiac magnetic resonance imaging for morphology and function without contrast material(s), followed by contrast material(s) and further sequences; with stress imaging                                                  |
| 76390                             | Magnetic resonance spectroscopy                                                                                                                                                                                           |
| 76498                             | Unlisted magnetic resonance procedure (e.g., diagnostic, interventional)                                                                                                                                                  |
| 77046                             | Magnetic resonance imaging, breast, without contrast material; unilateral                                                                                                                                                 |
| 77047                             | Magnetic resonance imaging, breast, without contrast material; bilateral                                                                                                                                                  |
| 77048                             | Magnetic resonance imaging, breast, without and with contrast material(s), including computer-aided detection (CAD real-time lesion detection, characterization and pharmacokinetic analysis), when performed; unilateral |
| 77049                             | Magnetic resonance imaging, breast, without and with contrast material(s), including computer-aided detection (CAD real-time lesion detection, characterization and pharmacokinetic analysis), when performed; bilateral  |
| 77084                             | Magnetic resonance (e.g., proton) imaging, bone marrow blood supply                                                                                                                                                       |

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| HCPSC Code                        | Description                                        |
|-----------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Magnetic Resonance Imaging</b> |                                                    |
| S8037                             | Magnetic resonance cholangiopancreatography (MRCP) |

## Clinical Evidence

### American College of Obstetricians and Gynecologists (ACOG)

ACOG's Committee on Obstetric Practice makes the following recommendations regarding diagnostic imaging procedures during pregnancy and lactation:

- Ultrasonography and magnetic resonance imaging (MRI) are not associated with risk and are the imaging techniques of choice for the pregnant patient, but they should be used prudently and only when use is expected to answer a relevant clinical question
- Radiation exposure through radiography, computed tomography (CT) scan, or nuclear medicine imaging techniques is at a dose much lower than the exposure associated with fetal harm

- The use of gadolinium contrast with MRI should be limited; it may be used as a contrast agent only if it significantly improves diagnostic performance and is expected to improve fetal or maternal outcome (ACOG, 2021)

### American Society of Anesthesiologists (ASA)

The 2015 ASA Practice Advisory on Anesthetic Care for Magnetic Resonance Imaging states that risks related to the patient may include age-related risks, health-related risks, and risks from foreign bodies located in or on the patient or implanted ferromagnetic items.

- Age-related risks apply to neonates or premature infants and the elderly
- Health-related risks include, but are not limited to:
  - Need for intensive or critical care
  - Impaired respiratory function (e.g., tonsillar hypertrophy and sleep apnea)
  - Changes in level of sedation, muscle relaxation, or ventilation
  - Hemodynamic instability and vasoactive infusion requirements
  - Comorbidities that may contribute to adverse MRI effects (e.g., burns or temperature increases in patients with obesity or peripheral vascular disease)
- Foreign bodies include nonmedical ferromagnetic items imbedded in the patient (e.g., eyeliner tattoos) or attached to the patient (e.g., pierced jewelry; implanted ferromagnetic items may include items such as aneurysm clips, prosthetic heart valves, or coronary arterial stents)

## References

American College of Obstetricians and Gynecologists. Committee opinion 723: Guidelines for diagnostic imaging during pregnancy and lactation. VOL. 130, NO. 4. October 2017, Reaffirmed October 2021.

American Society of Anesthesiologists. Practice Advisory on anesthetic care for magnetic resonance imaging. Anesthesiology. V 122; No 3. March 2015.

## Policy History/Revision Information

| Date       | Summary of Changes                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
|------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 03/01/2025 | <b>Applicable Codes</b><br><b>Computed Tomography</b> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Added CPT code 0042T</li> </ul> <b>Supporting Information</b> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Archived previous policy version MP.13.15</li> </ul> |

## Instructions for Use

This Medical Policy provides assistance in interpreting UnitedHealthcare standard benefit plans. When deciding coverage, the member specific benefit plan document must be referenced as the terms of the member specific benefit plan may differ from the standard plan. In the event of a conflict, the member specific benefit plan document governs. Before using this policy, please check the member specific benefit plan document and any applicable federal or state mandates. UnitedHealthcare reserves the right to modify its Policies and Guidelines as necessary. This Medical Policy is provided for informational purposes. It does not constitute medical advice.

This Medical Policy may also be applied to Medicare Advantage plans in certain instances. In the absence of a Medicare National Coverage Determination (NCD), Local Coverage Determination (LCD), or other Medicare coverage guidance, CMS allows a Medicare Advantage Organization (MAO) to create its own coverage determinations, using objective evidence-based rationale relying on authoritative evidence ([Medicare IOM Pub. No. 100-16, Ch. 4, §90.5](#)).

UnitedHealthcare may also use tools developed by third parties, such as the InterQual® criteria, to assist us in administering health benefits. UnitedHealthcare Medical Policies are intended to be used in connection with the independent professional medical judgment of a qualified health care provider and do not constitute the practice of medicine or medical advice.